



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Power + Muscle development

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Power

Power is force multiplied by speed. A jump shot, a duel at pivot or a first step all require producing a lot of force in a fraction of a second.

- **Push heavy:** increase your maximum strength with heavy loads and few reps.
- **Move fast:** turn that strength into fast movements (throws, jumps, pushes).
- **Link the two:** pair a heavy exercise with a similar fast movement (contrast method).

The golden rules

- **Few reps, lots of rest:** 3 to 5 reps, 2 to 3 minutes of recovery.
- **Every rep at maximum speed,** even with a heavy load: the intent is what counts.
- Heavy loads only if your technique is perfect.

For heavy loads, get another person to spot you or use a power rack with the safety bars set.

Muscle development

In handball, you take contacts in every attack and every defence. Stronger muscles protect your joints and make you harder to knock off balance.

- **Strength:** pushing, pulling and lifting heavier.
- **Mass gain:** building muscle size.
- **Core and stability:** transferring force from your legs to your arm and staying stable in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Technique first:** a load only goes up if the movement stays clean.
- **Progress a little every week:** one more rep, or a slightly heavier load.
- **Control the descent:** 2 to 3 seconds down, then back up with energy.
- Keep 2 to 3 reps in reserve: never train to failure.

Mass gain: training sends the signal, but muscles are built with food and sleep. Eat enough, with protein at every meal, and sleep 8 hours. For nutrition advice, see a registered dietitian.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Power: moderate loads to learn the movements, light throws.

Muscle development: light loads, learning the movements.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

9	 Squat (moderate load)	2-3 × 6	2 min
10	 Two-handed ball throw	2-3 × 5	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	 Squat	2-3 × 10	75 s
11	 Dumbbell bench press	2-3 × 10	60 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
12	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
13	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

14	 Hip thrust	2-3 × 8	90 s
15	 Rotational throw	2 × 5 per side	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

16	 Romanian deadlift	2-3 × 10	75 s
17	 Row	2-3 × 10	60 s
18	 Pallof press	2 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

22	 Bench press	2-3 × 6	2 min
23	 Box jump	2-3 × 4	75 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

24	 Reverse lunge	2-3 × 8 per leg	60 s
25	 Shoulder press	2-3 × 10	60 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

26	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
27	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
28	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
12	 Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
13	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
29	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
30	 Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
31	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Power: this is the phase where you push heavy, increase the loads every week.

Muscle development: this is the key phase, increase the loads every week. If your goal is mass gain, do 8 to 12 reps with 60 to 90 s of rest.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

32	Heavy squat	3-4 × 4-5	3 min
10	Two-handed ball throw	3 × 5	75 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	Squat	3-4 × 6-8	2 min
11	Dumbbell bench press	3-4 × 8	90 s
33	Farmer's walk	3 × 20 m	60 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
12	Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
13	Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

34	 Heavy hip thrust	3-4 × 5	2 min
35	 Heavy pull	3 × 5	2 min
15	 Rotational throw	3 × 4 per side	60 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

14	 Hip thrust	3-4 × 8	90 s
36	 Pull-ups (or row)	3-4 × 6-8	90 s
18	 Pallof press	3 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

22	Bench press	3-4 × 4-5	3 min
23	Box jump	3 × 4	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

37	Bulgarian split squat	3 × 8 per leg	90 s
16	Romanian deadlift	3 × 8	90 s
25	Shoulder press	3 × 8	75 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

26	Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
27	Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
28	Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Power: every heavy set is followed straight away by an explosive movement (contrast).

Muscle development: fewer sets, loads still heavy.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

32	Heavy squat	3 × 3	back to back
38	Loaded squat jump	3 × 4	3 min after the pair

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	Squat	3 × 5	2 min
11	Dumbbell bench press	3 × 8	75 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
12	Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
13	Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

22	Bench press	3 × 3	back to back
39	Plyometric push-ups	3 × 4	3 min after the pair

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

14	Hip thrust	3 × 6	90 s
36	Pull-ups (or row)	3 × 6	90 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 POWER

15-20 min

40	Overhead throw	3 × 4	75 s
15	Rotational throw	3 × 4 per side	75 s
23	Box jump	3 × 3	90 s

3 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

24	Reverse lunge	3 × 6 per leg	90 s
18	Pallof press	2 × 10 per side	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

26	Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
27	Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
28	Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week 8 - Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Power:** Same loads, same speed.
- **Muscle development:** Same loads.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: light jog, then running drills (high knees, butt kicks). Otherwise: drills on the spot or in the gym's open space: 5 minutes of high knees, butt kicks and side shuffles.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Take a big step forward, lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3



Walking hip opener

As you walk, lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, and put your foot down one step further. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



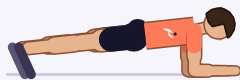
4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



6 Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7 Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

8 **Progressive accelerations**

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 3 accelerations of 5 seconds, faster each time. Otherwise: 3 accelerations of 10 seconds on an assault bike (air bike) or a rowing machine.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

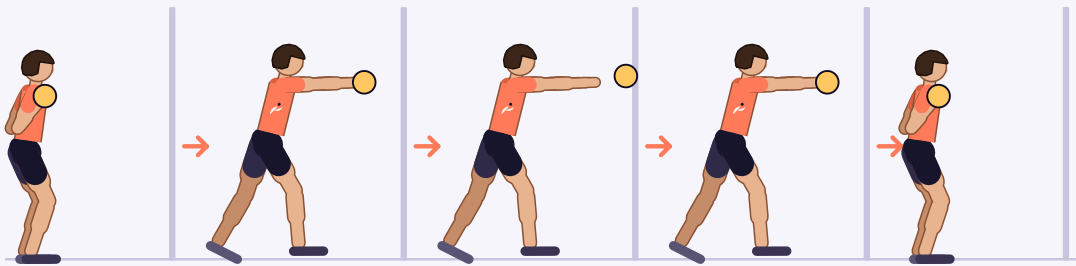


9 Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, a dumbbell held against your chest (goblet squat), lower until your thighs are at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. Heavier: barbell on your upper back.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

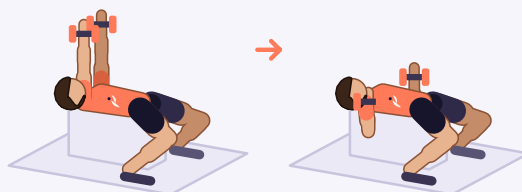
Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.



10 Two-handed ball throw

Facing a wall, 2 to 4 kg medicine ball at your chest, throw as hard as you can.

Key points: Push with your legs and arms at the same time.



11 Dumbbell bench press

Lying on a bench, a dumbbell in each hand, lower the dumbbells to chest level, elbows at 45°, then push.

Key points: Elbows at 45° from your body, the hips do not sag.

Easier: Push-ups, hands on a bench.

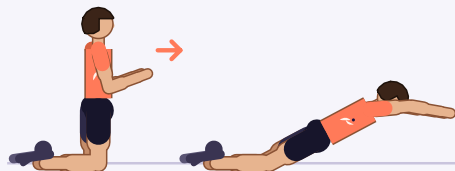


12 Side plank

On your side, on one forearm and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.

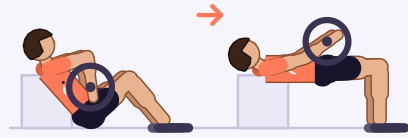


13 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a mat, feet anchored under a loaded bench, under wall bars or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.

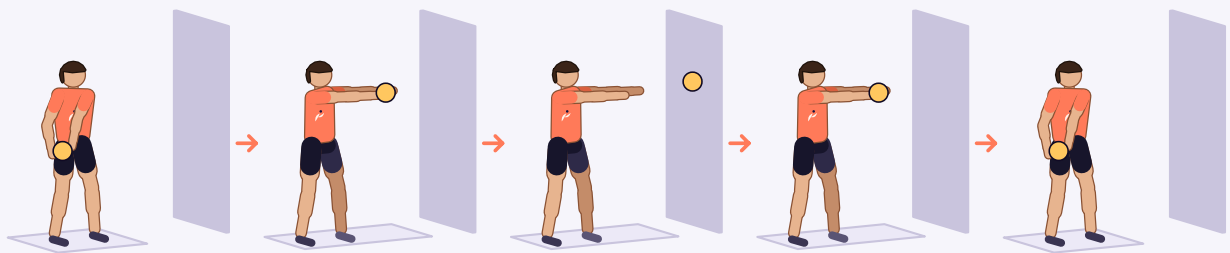


14 Hip thrust

Upper back against a bench, barbell (with a pad) or dumbbell on your hips, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top for one second. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.

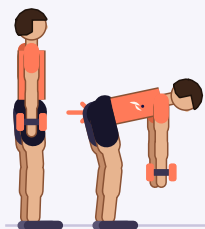
Easier: Glute bridge on the floor.



15 Rotational throw

Side-on to the wall, 2 to 4 kg medicine ball held at your hip, pivot and throw sideways, like a shot.

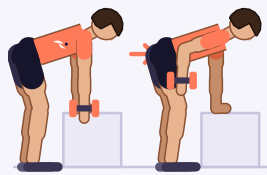
Key points: The movement starts from the hips, not the arms.



16 Romanian deadlift

Knees slightly bent, a barbell or two dumbbells in your hands, tip your trunk forward by pushing your hips back, flat back, then stand up.

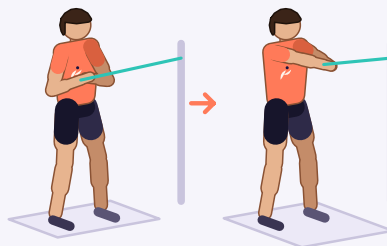
Key points: Flat back from start to finish, the load slides along your legs.



17 Row

Trunk bent forward, flat back, free hand on a bench: pull a dumbbell towards your hip. Other option: seated cable row.

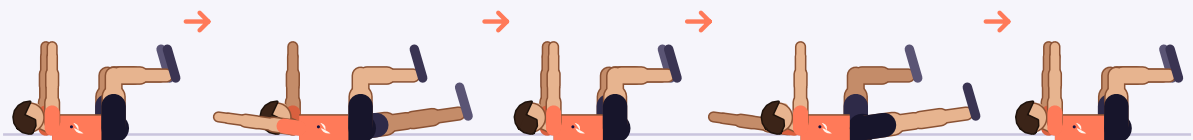
Key points: Pull with your back, the shoulder blade moves towards the spine.



18 Pallof press

On a cable set at chest height (or with a band), side-on: press your arms out in front of you without letting your trunk rotate, hold for 2 seconds.

Key points: Resist the rotation: this is a core exercise.



19 Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

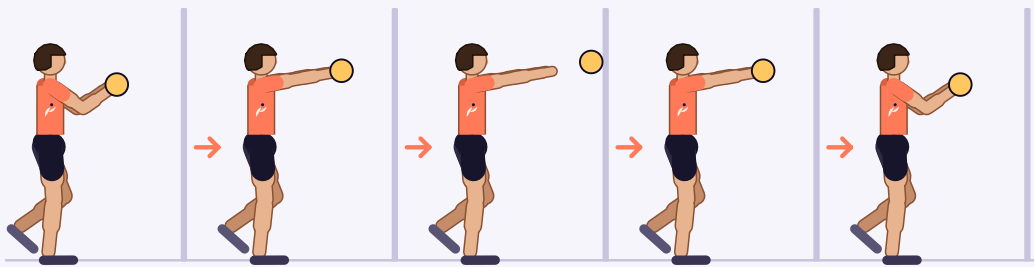
Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



20 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

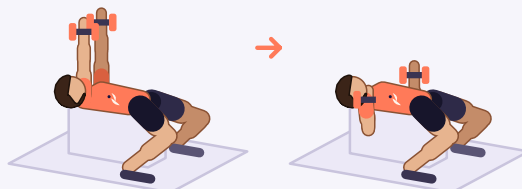
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



21 Balance with a ball

On one leg, on a bosu or a wobble board, throw a ball against a wall and catch it.

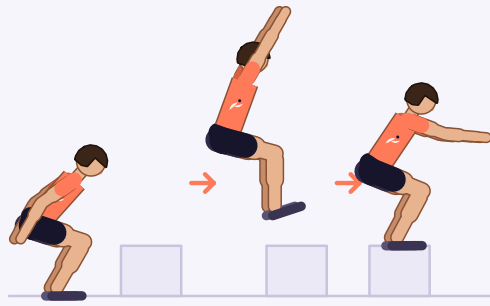
Key points: The standing knee stays in line.



22 Bench press

Bench press with a barbell (or heavy dumbbells), feet on the floor, shoulder blades squeezed.

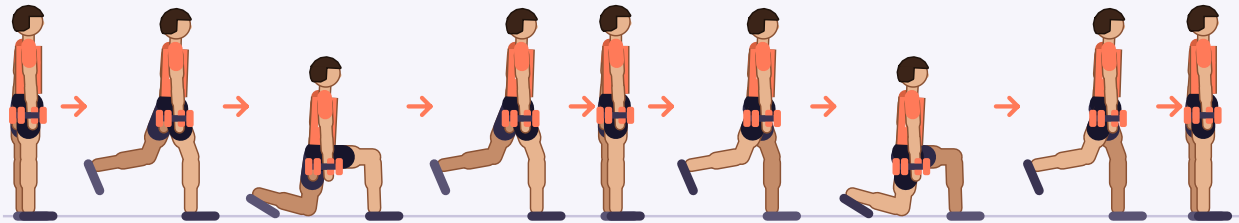
Key points: Shoulder blades squeezed, explosive push.



23 Box jump

Jump onto a plyo box, land softly, step back down.

Key points: Jump high, not far. Stepping down protects your tendons. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

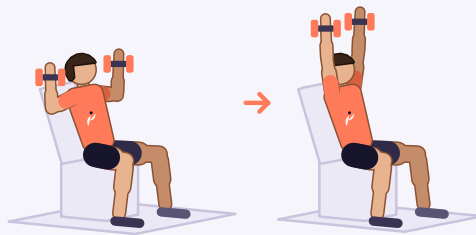


24 Reverse lunge

A dumbbell in each hand, step one leg back and lower until the back knee almost touches the floor, then come back by pushing through the front leg and switch legs (the front foot stays planted).

Key points: Upright trunk, front knee above the ankle.

Easier: With support (wall, chair).

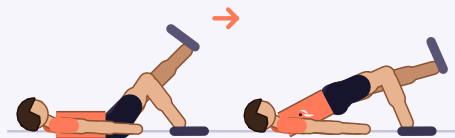


25 Shoulder press

Seated on a bench, backrest inclined at 70°, back well supported: press the dumbbells overhead, then lower back to your shoulders.

Key points: Tight core, do not arch your lower back.

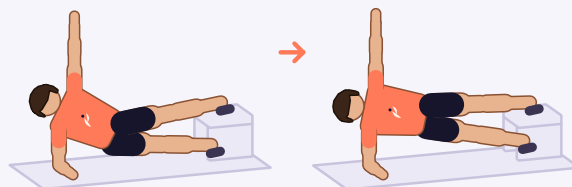
Easier: Pike push-ups (hips up).



26 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

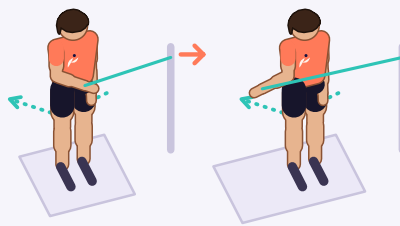
Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



27 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm, top leg resting on a bench (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.



28 Shoulder external rotation

On a cable set at elbow height (or with a band): elbow tucked in and bent at 90°, move your forearm outwards, then come back slowly.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

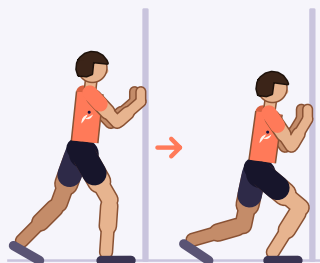
Easier: Without a band.



29 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

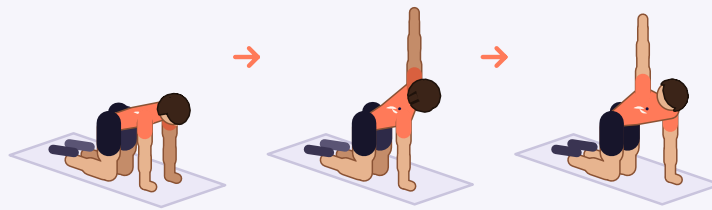
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



30 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, foot 10 cm away, drive your knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

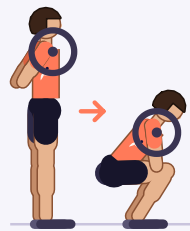
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



31 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

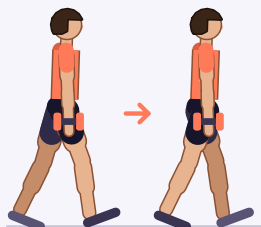
Key points: The pelvis does not move.



32 Heavy squat

Squat with a barbell on your upper back (or heavy dumbbells), 3 to 5 reps.

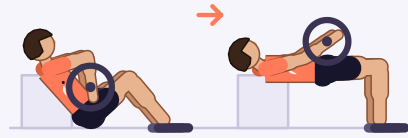
Key points: Controlled descent, stand up as fast as possible.



33 Farmer's walk

Walk 20 m with a heavy dumbbell or kettlebell in each hand.

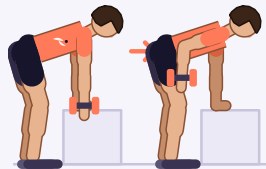
Key points: Shoulders down, upright trunk, steady steps.



34 Heavy hip thrust

Upper back on a bench, heavy barbell on your hips, drive your hips up forcefully.

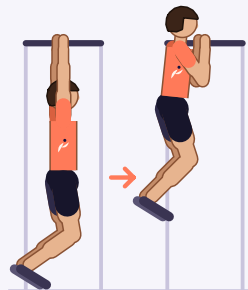
Key points: Push through your heels, lock your glutes at the top. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



35 Heavy pull

Heavy one-arm row with a dumbbell, or weighted pull-ups.

Key points: Pull fast, lower slowly.

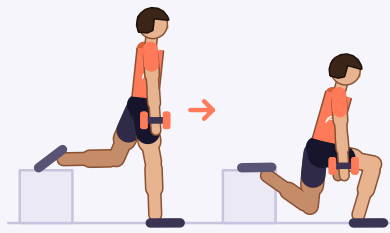


36 Pull-ups

Hanging from a bar, pull until your chin is over it, then lower. Other option: lat pulldown.

Key points: Controlled descent, arms almost straight at the bottom.

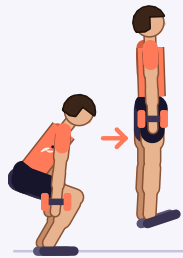
Easier: With a band or the assisted machine.



37 Bulgarian split squat

Back foot on a bench, a dumbbell in each hand, lower on the front leg then stand back up.

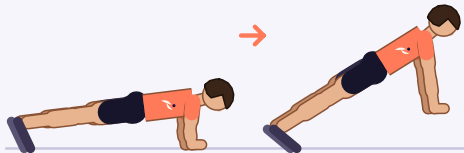
Key points: The front leg does the work, the back foot is only for balance.



38 Loaded squat jump

Squat jump with two light dumbbells by your sides (10 to 20 % of your body weight).

Key points: Stable landing, knees in line. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

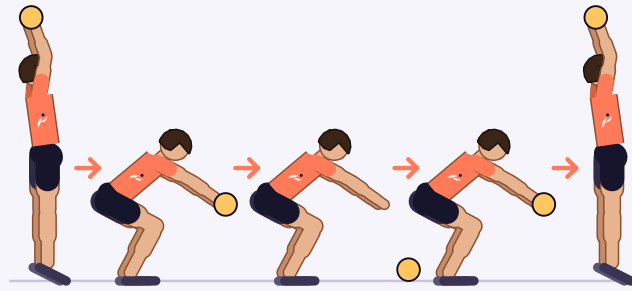


39 Plyometric push-ups

Push hard enough for your hands to leave the floor on every rep.

Key points: Land with your arms slightly bent.

Easier: Hands on a bench.



40 Overhead throw

Slam ball above your head, throw it hard into the floor.

Key points: Your whole body takes part, tight core.